As Stratcom commander, Cecil Haney focused extensively on the nexus of personnel and release procedures, and in conversation worries about how a dictatorship will structure its nuclear enterprise. Will North Korea institute the inviolable two-person rule adopted by the United States, whereby no single individual has launch authority, or even the ability to be alone at any time with a nuclear weapon? In the case of US missile silo crews, not only must both launch officers turn their launch keys at exactly the same time, but a second two-man crew in a separate complex must also do so at the same instant, thereby launching together all the missiles under the control of the two groups. Will Kim trust two officers to work together, or does he believe fear is enough to keep a single officer with launch authority in line?

Even more opaque is the question of who will have ultimate launch authority at individual sites. It is hard to imagine the dictator of one of the world's most ruthless and hierarchical states allowing subordinate officers the autonomy to launch nuclear missiles. Yet if Kim fears a "decapitation strike" by US or South Korean forces, he might issue orders that delegate launch authority to dispersed units. One can envision a scenario during a crisis in which a panicky junior officer loses communication with upper-level commanders and decides that he needs to launch before he is attacked or because he believes a first strike has taken out Kim.

If Pyongyang does not have reliable communications with its nuclear launch systems and personnel, then the uncertainty in nuclear operations increases dramatically. This in turn will put pressure on US commanders who are trying to decide how North Korea may respond to any American action. "If they did something and we responded," Kowalski said, describing one of his greatest concerns, "we have to be careful to understand their command and control system and not interfere. You don't want to put into motion an automatic delegation system where a junior officer has launch authority."

Here is where the third *C*, communications, becomes vital. The stress of maintaining the required level of training and proficiency, not